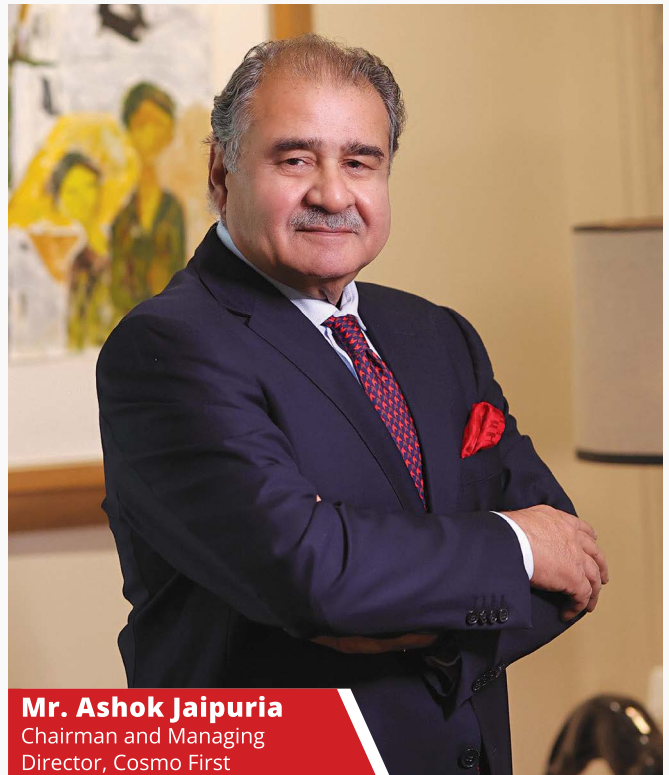


# The Pivot Artist : How Ashok Jaipuria Built a Packaging Empire, Then Reinvented His Playbook With Pet Care

Four decades after pioneering India's BOPP film industry, the 71-year-old entrepreneur is showing that staying ahead means constantly rewriting the playbook and reinventing oneself ahead of the curve - most recently with a bold foray into pet care.



**Mr. Ashok Jaipuria**  
Chairman and Managing  
Director, Cosmo First

In 1981, when Ashok Jaipuria commissioned India's first biaxially-oriented polypropylene (BOPP) film plant in Aurangabad, Maharashtra, the bet seemed quixotic. India's packaging industry was primitive, technical expertise scarce, and global competitors formidable. Yet Jaipuria saw what others missed: a country on the cusp of consumption growth desperately needed modern packaging infrastructure.

"At that time, the Indian market was still reliant on conventional materials, and there was a clear gap for advanced, durable, and versatile packaging solutions," Jaipuria recalls. That gap gave birth to Cosmo Films—now Cosmo First—a company that exports to over 100 countries and partners with large global FMCG players like Nestlé, PepsiCo, Coca-Cola, P&G, and Hindustan Unilever for their packaging solution needs.

The trajectory from a new domestic entrant to global player followed a familiar script: capacity expansion, export markets, incremental innovation. By the 2000s, Cosmo ranked among the world's top BOPP producers with 469,400 tonnes per annum capacity. But Jaipuria recognized the commoditization trap. His response? A strategic pivot toward specialty films, which now constitute 70% of Cosmo's

portfolio and have grown at 10% CAGR over six years—delivering the margins commodity businesses cannot.

Then came the disruptive move. In September 2021, Jaipuria launched Zigly, India's first organized omnichannel pet care brand. The shift from packaging products to pet care may appear unconventional, but it follows a familiar playbook : enter fragmented, underdeveloped categories and formalize them through scale, standards and strong operating discipline.

"I want our company to be the 'First' choice for all our stakeholders including our clients, partners, employees and consumers," Jaipuria explains, articulating the philosophy behind his serial market-making. With 35+ experience centers across major cities and aggressive expansion plans, Zigly is replicating Cosmo's playbook in consumer retail: identify white space, build infrastructure, establish standards.

The diversification extends beyond pet care. The Cosmo First group expanded with 3 new ventures after Zigly. Cosmo Speciality Chemicals addresses packaging masterbatches and adhesive needs and Cosmo Plastech brings rigid packaging solutions. Cosmo Sunshield and Cosmo PPF serve automotive and architectural films. Each venture follows the

same strategy: enter unorganized sectors with organized solutions, leveraging manufacturing expertise and distribution networks built over decades.

A strong sustainability spine ties Cosmo's diverse verticals together. Renewables now meet 50% of its energy needs, set to rise to 65% delivering savings of ₹20-25 crore annually. New BOPP and CPP lines produce mono-layered, recyclable structures and Cosmo Synthetic Paper eliminates pulp altogether. These support circular economy principles , with responsible quality solutions.

Through Cosmo Foundation, Jaipuria has extended impact beyond commerce—touching 750,000+ lives through education initiatives, planting 110,000+ fruit trees with 92% survival rates, and establishing urban forests. The foundation's Basic English Learning Capsule serves 68,000 students across 55 schools and 155 villages.

At 71, most founders would be orchestrating succession but Jaipuria is constantly reinventing. These new businesses in the near future will create significant value for the group. Exploring such avenues alongside protecting existing strengths, Jaipuria demonstrates that real longevity comes from staying restless – from leaders who choose reinvention over comfort.